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Peripheral pandemic

Logitech's views on how the pandemic affected the PC peripherals business

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The Covid-19 pandemic has adversely affected a lot of businesses but few of them have posted phenomenal growths. The peripherals segment has been one which has seen a lot of growth. We talked to Srinivas Rao Vishnubhotla, Country Head for Logitech India to understand how things shaped up for Logitech over the last year.

Q How has the consumer purchasing behaviour changed post-Covid? Has that been consistent across all your product lines since there's a wide difference between your different product lines.

Srinivas: Basically, we have had this trend because of the pandemic wherein folks have been bound to their homes and we've seen a lot of buying happening on the online portals. Having said that, our offline share has also been increasing as well. What has happened is that most people are looking for a hybrid work model, wherein you have a small home office and then you have to travel to office once in a week or so. So, what we've seen is a

tremendous amount of growth happening across our work-from-home portfolio. People are spending more time playing from home as well. We call it work-from-home, play-from-home, stream-from-home, create-from-home, etc. A lot of these categories have seen a phenomenal growth as well.

Q Do you expect this growth to continue in the post-Covid era? Because you'd assume that there would be some level of normalisation happening and the growth would level-off.

Srinivas: Yes, from that perspective there would be some level of normalisation happening but we have been on a very secular growth trend in gaming and the pandemic has given a tailwind to this business. Having said that, people are looking at hybrid work spaces and that presents a new avenue for the growth to continue.

Q Was there any need to introduce new SKUs in light of the changing buying behaviours? We can see that webcams in laptops are improving where previously they used to be absolutely horrible. Logitech has had good webcams to begin with but have you had to shift your focus in any way?

Srinivas: From Logitech's perspective, whatever products we make, we ensure that the design element is at the centre of everything and we keep consumer preferences in mind.

We've never had to issue any specific SKUs because of the pandemic. We've always had a solid portfolio across the work-from-home and stream-from-home categories. It was just that we had a huge demand surge in products with which we couldn't catch up. But now we are catching up in terms of supplies. To answer your questions, we've not had to issue any new SKUs.

Q In the enthusiast segment, we see major trend shifts happening frequently. Right now we have the trend of Ultralight gaming mice but we don't see any representation from Logitech in India despite the US and EU markets having products such as the Logitech G Pro X Superlight. Why haven't we seen those products come to India yet?

Srinivas: The best products selling globally are available in India. For example, the G502 Hero was rated as one of the best gaming mice by Time Magazine. We also have the G502 Lightspeed wireless mouse which is also available in India. We also have the G733 headset selling in India. Typically, whatever products are launched globally, we do bring them to India and I think our consumers are delighted to latch onto those products.

Q There's still a significant delay between international product launches and the same coming out in India?

Srinivas: These are certain working conditions and certifications issues that are taking a little longer because of the pandemic. Otherwise, our global and Indian launches are more or less simultaneous.

Q So, do you feel any need to move production, in part or full, of some products to India so as to compensate for these certification issues?

Srinivas: We haven't really seen too much of a problem there. However, we keep evaluating opportunities depending upon the situation and we'll look into it depending on the business requirements, as and when they come up. **Q**